Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

# So you're thinking about business

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Business landed in an unusual place.

Not the worst score. But the only field in the whole index with no safe end.

Business analyst: 7.6 out of 10. General management: 4.9. Everything else in between.

Every other career we scored — nursing, medicine, law, the trades, engineering — has some protected core you can aim for. Business has a protected ceiling and nothing underneath it.

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## The 60-second version

- The destinations are genuinely good. General management, operations, commercial leadership.
- **But nothing in business scores below 4.9**, and there's no licence, no qualification barrier, nothing structural protecting you.
- The entry-level work — reports, decks, research, coordination — is exactly what AI took.
- The bigger problem isn't AI at all. It's that this is the most-taken degree in the country.
- Which program you choose matters more here than in any other career we score.

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## The thing to understand first

Here's the shape of it.

A nurse is protected on day one because the law requires a licensed human. A doctor is protected on day one. An electrician is protected because you can't rewire a house through a screen.

A manager is protected only once they're accountable for something. Which means at 22, with nothing yet to be accountable for, you have exactly none of the protection this field offers.

You have to earn it — and the route people traditionally earned it on is the part that got automated.

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## The scores

| WHERE YOU END UP | SCORE |
| --- | --- |
| General management (owning a P&L) | 4.9 |
| Supply chain & operations | 5.0 |
| HR / people | 5.3 |
| Project management | 6.1 |
| Business analyst / coordinator | 7.6 |

The whole map in one line: exposure falls as accountability rises. Roles where you own a number score better. Roles where you support someone else's number score worse.

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## What AI actually took

Report building. Dashboards. Deck assembly. Market research. Process documentation. Requirements gathering. Meeting notes and status tracking.

That list is a fairly complete description of what a business graduate was hired to do in 2019.

There's a second problem in there, and it's subtler. Building those reports was how people used to learn how a business actually worked. You couldn't assemble a P&L pack for two years without understanding the company. It was tedious, and it was the education.

Nobody has built a replacement yet.

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## The number that matters more than our score

We'll be straight with you: for business, the most important evidence isn't ours.

The Federal Reserve Bank of New York tracks what happens to graduates. As of early 2026:

- Recent graduate unemployment: **5.7%** (national average: 4.2%)
- **Underemployment: 41.5%** — meaning four in ten graduates are working in jobs that don't need a degree

Now the comparison worth sitting with. **Nursing has the lowest underemployment of any major they track: 12.8%.**

That gap isn't about intelligence or effort. It's about whether a degree points at a specific job that legally requires it. Nursing does. General business doesn't.

**So our honest position:** business's biggest problem isn't AI. It's that it's the most-conferred degree in the country with nothing capping the numbers, and automation arrived on top of that. We measure the automation. We can't measure the oversupply. For this career, the thing we can't measure might matter more.

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## Which is why the program matters more than the degree

More than in any other career we scored. Four things separate a good business degree from a weak one:

**A placement year — and whether it's actually guaranteed.** "Placement available" that only 30% of students get isn't a placement program. Ask for the number. Employers now rate internship experience as the single highest-weighted hiring factor — 4.5 out of 5. In a field with no licence, the placement is the closest thing you'll get to one.

**Real quantitative content, compulsory rather than optional.** That's the judgment layer. The reporting layer is what's automating.

**A genuine specialization.** Operations and supply chain score best in the field and are chronically under-chosen — they deal with physical, real-world constraints that resist automation.

**First-destination job titles, not employment rates.** "94% employed" tells you nothing. Ask what they're *doing*.

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## The version that doesn't work

A general business degree, no specialization, no placement, pointed at an analyst job.

That's the weakest combination in this profile — and it's also the most commonly taken.

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## The honest question

This one's uncomfortable, and we'd rather ask it than skip it.

**Is business a positive choice, or the thing left over after you ruled other stuff out?**

Both are completely legitimate at seventeen. But they need different advice. Business rewards people who are genuinely curious about how organizations work — why they succeed, why they fail, what makes people move. It's unusually unforgiving of people who aren't, because there's no credential carrying you.

If nothing else stood out, the better move is to look wider first rather than to default here. Operations, supply chain, construction management and the skilled trades all score better and are consistently under-chosen by people who'd be good at them.

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## What's genuinely good about it

We should say this too, because the score doesn't capture it.

**Progression is fast.** Business advances on demonstrated competence rather than time served. Someone capable can be running something at 26 in a way that's structurally impossible in medicine or law.

**Ownership is a normal outcome**, not an exotic one. The same absence of a licence that removes the floor also removes the ceiling — nobody can stop you starting something.

**Breadth and optionality.** The skills move across industries and countries more easily than most.

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## Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- Are **comfortable being accountable in public** — this is the core protective trait
- Are genuinely curious about **how organizations work**
- Can be **useful without being told what to do** — the biggest early differentiator
- Want to know **why something makes money**, not just that it does

It's harder if you want clear structure and defined tasks — that's precisely the automating layer — or if you need a credential to feel qualified.

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## Two things worth doing

**Find someone three to five years into a business career.** Ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that job still exists in the same form. The answer will be more useful than any brochure.

**Then get some real commercial responsibility before you apply.** A Saturday job where you're trusted with something. A small venture. Running an actual thing at school. In a field with no credential, evidence is the credential — and almost nobody your age has any.

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**If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes**

- **The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates** — read this one first. It's a central bank, not a careers site, and you can look up unemployment and underemployment by major yourself. Compare business against nursing and engineering.
- **Talent Disrupted** — on why starting underemployed tends to stick rather than sort itself out.
- **Too many graduates flood the white-collar market** — this argues our score is really measuring oversupply rather than AI. We think it's substantially right, which is why it's here.

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*There's a longer version behind this — full scores, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a business school, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.*